western extremity of the Nam Ka Chu. The Punjabis were to be replaced by 2 Rajput's Bravo Company under the command of Second Lieutenant Subash Chander. Charlie Company was also told to move forward to Serkhim, just south of Hathung-la, and was to be a reserve company if 9 Punjab found itself in need of reinforcements.

Referring to Thapar's orders, Prasad then broached the subject of an attack plan with Dalvi, who predictably exploded, refusing to be part of any such sham exercise. 'My first reaction to the GOC's request for assistance in the preparation of a formal appreciation, for onward transmission to Delhi, for implementing these preposterous tasks, was to refuse point blank. I exchanged some hot words with General Prasad. Chief or no chief, there was no question of evicting the Chinese.'

The three-point guideline for the preparation of the appreciation was along the same lines as before: evict the Chinese from the north bank of the Nam Ka Chu; contain Thagla; and patrol towards Tsangle. Caught in a complete bind, Dalvi and Prasad had only two choices—refuse to execute the order, or prepare an appreciation that would focus on the problems and underline the impossibility of the assigned task.

The first part of the appreciation did just that, underlining the impossibility of trying to maintain troops on the Nam Ka Chu, especially since the logistics routes ran over Hathung-la and Karpo-la 1 at heights in excess of 15,000 feet. Also highlighted was the disparity in existing firepower between the two sides, especially when it came to artillery and heavy mortars. The second part of the appreciation, however, was the critical bit—and here too, the terrain dictated the options. A thrust from the direction of Khenzemane was out of the question as the approach was blocked by steep slopes and guarded by the Chinese. Similarly, a south-north thrust along the middle section of the valley, which was bisected by the Paitsai spur, heavily defended by the Chinese, would mean our troops would be decimated in the form-up areas itself. Hence, militarily, the only possible approach was to push troops up from Bridge 4 to Bridge 5, get to Tsangle in strength, and then try to capture the Thagla Ridge moving west to east.

The appreciation was based on two important premises: one, the route from Bridge 4 to Bridge 5 was along the Nam Ka Chu and two, the strength of the Chinese across the Nam Ka Chu did not exceed that of an infantry battalion. In fact, both these premises were way off the mark. It was not